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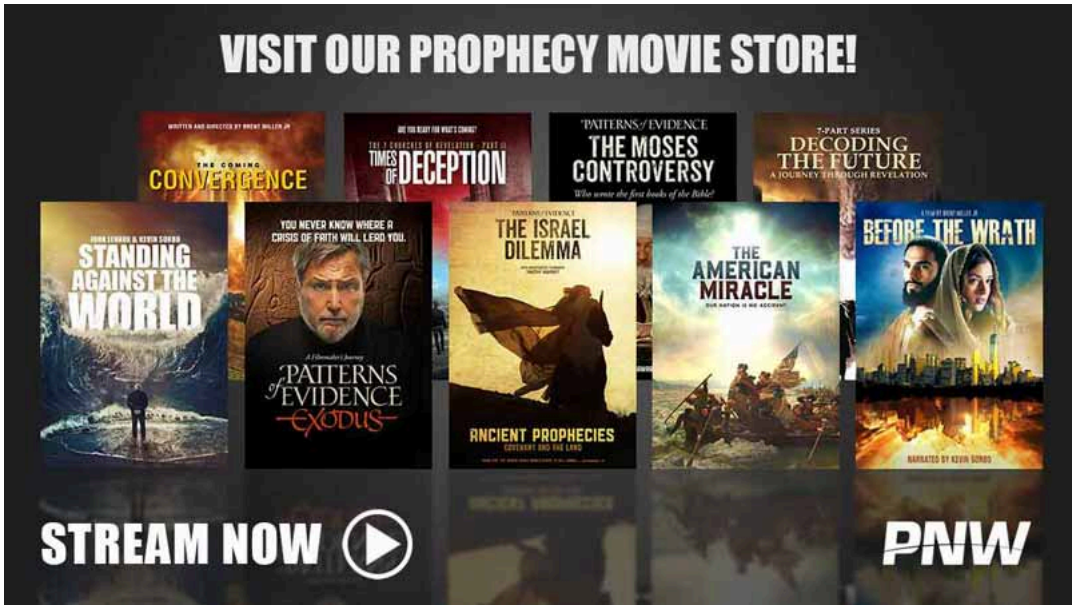

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ARTICLE

Would Luther Recognize This Church? ELCA's Bishop Race Is Sign Of The Times

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Bibletoday.com

BY PNW STAFF APRIL 17, 2026

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Last weekend, the Saint Paul Area Synod of the Evangelical Lutheran Church in America hosted its highly anticipated "meet the candidates" forum for the next bishop. For those still holding to historic Christian teaching, the reactions likely fell into two camps: shock--or a weary lack of surprise.

Shock, because of just how openly the candidates reflect a theological departure from Scripture. And yet, for others, no surprise at all--because this moment feels less like a sudden fall and more like the inevitable result of years of gradual drift

This was not merely a routine leadership event. It was a revealing snapshot of where the denomination stands today--and perhaps more importantly, where it is heading. Of the five candidates presented, three are in openly same-sex relationships, and all are aligned with gender-affirming theology. That reality is not incidental; it is central. The future leadership of the synod is being drawn from a pool that already reflects a decisive shift away from traditional biblical doctrine on sexuality and identity.

Tai Chi Exercises For Elderly

And then there is the setting. The forum took place at Roseville Lutheran Church--a congregation that many say tells the story of the ELCA in microcosm. Once known for more biblically grounded leadership, the church chose to remain within the denomination as it evolved. Today, it has a transgender-identifying pastor. For critics, that transformation is not just symbolic--it is deeply instructive. What was once unthinkable within Lutheran pastoral leadership is now normalized, even platformed at a major synod event.

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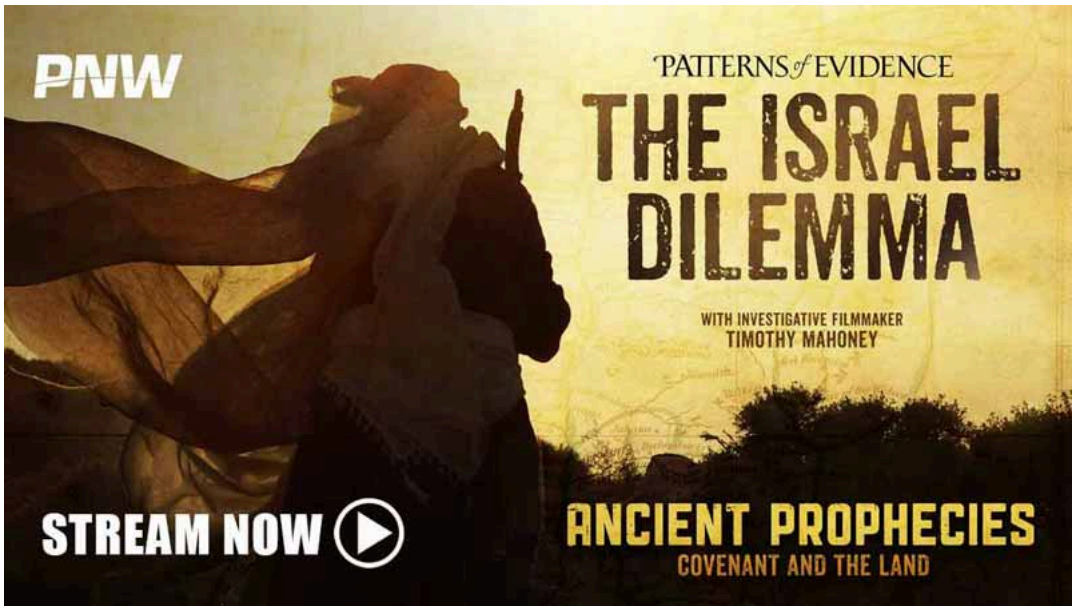
gender dysphoria or same-sex attraction. But historically, that love has always been paired with a call to transformation--to repentance, to renewal, to alignment with God's design rather than the redefinition of it.



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That tension is at the heart of the current controversy. In the Gospel of Matthew 19:4, Jesus points back to creation itself: "male and female He created them." For centuries, the church has understood this as foundational--not just to theology, but to anthropology. When church leaders now openly challenge or reinterpret that framework, it is not a secondary issue. It is a reworking of core doctrine.

What makes this moment particularly significant is how institutionalized these changes have become. This is not a fringe movement operating on the edges of the church. It is embedded in the leadership pipeline. Candidates are not being reluctantly tolerated despite their views--they are being advanced, presented, and seriously considered because those views align with the current trajectory of the denomination.

And that raises a difficult but necessary question: who bears responsibility for this direction?

It is easy to point to denominational leaders or seminary systems. But the reality is more complex. Churches are sustained by congregations--by individuals who attend, give, and participate. Continued engagement, even when marked by quiet discomfort, can function as a form of affirmation. At what point does staying become a statement in itself?

History offers a sobering comparison. Martin Luther did not set out to divide the church, but he refused to ignore what he saw as clear departures from biblical truth. The Reformation was born not out of convenience, but conviction. It came at a cost. And it forced believers to decide where they stood.

Today, many find themselves facing a different but related crossroads. The question is no longer whether the ELCA is shifting--that is evident. The question is how individuals and congregations will respond.

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What unfolded last weekend was more than a candidate forum. It was a window into a denomination redefining itself in real time. For some, it represents progress. For others, it signals profound compromise.

Either way, the direction is becoming clearer--and harder to ignore.

The deeper issue now is not just who will be elected bishop. It is whether the church itself still recognizes the authority it once claimed to stand upon.

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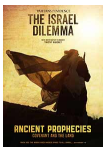

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